

GRADE 7 · READING LITERATURE · RL.7.3

# How Story Elements Interact

Characters · Setting · Plot — and how each one changes the others

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Definitions · Models · Task Cards · Passages · Multiple-Choice Practice

# What You Will Learn Today

## Learning Goals

Name the elements of a story or drama

Explain what "interact" means in RL.7.3

Trace how setting shapes a character

Trace how a character drives the plot

Support answers with text evidence

## How the Lesson Runs

Definitions with quick examples

One modeled example together

Three task cards for partner work

Three short passages, all multiple choice

Answer key and exit ticket

# Unpacking the Standard

## GUIDE NOTE

"Analyze how particular elements of a story or drama interact." You are not just naming characters and places — you are showing how one element changes another.

## Naming (not enough)

"The story takes place during a blizzard, and Jonas is the main character."

## Analyzing (what RL.7.3 asks)

"The blizzard traps Jonas inside, so he finally has to talk to the brother he has avoided all year."

# Element: Character

## Character

The people (or creatures) in a story — what they want, what they fear, and the choices they make.

## Example

Maya wants to be noticed at her new school, but she is afraid of looking desperate — so she says nothing.

## Look For

What the character wants

What gets in the way

Choices and reactions

# Element: Setting

## Setting

Where and when the story happens — the place, the time period, the weather, and the social rules of that world.

## Example

A loud, overcrowded cafeteria in the first week of a new school year.

## Look For

Place and time words

Mood the place creates

Limits the place puts on characters

# Element: Plot

## Plot

The chain of events: what happens, in what order, and why one event causes the next.

## Example

The ferry is canceled, so Ravi must walk the cliff road, so he arrives late and soaked.

## Look For

Cause-and-effect words

The central problem

Turning points

# Elements of Drama

## Dialogue & Stage Directions

In a drama there is no narrator. Dialogue is what characters say; stage directions tell how they move, sound, and where they are.

### Example

ELENA: (folding his jersey) You can still walk in tomorrow.

### Look For

Who speaks, and who stays silent

Directions in parentheses

Scene and act breaks

# The Key Word: Interact

**Interact** — to act on one another. Each element pushes, limits, or changes the other two.

## Setting → Character

A place can calm a character, scare her, or change how she behaves.

## Character → Plot

A character's choice starts the next event in the chain.

## Plot → Character

Events force characters to change, decide, or reveal who they are.

# Picture the Three Elements Working Together



## Read the Arrows

Every arrow is an interaction

Arrows point both ways

Change one element and the others shift

Your job: explain one arrow with evidence

# Modeled Example: Follow One Arrow

## Mini Text

The power died at 6:04. Without the hum of the house, Theo could hear his sister crying through the wall — a sound the noise had hidden for months. He set down his controller, and for the first time all year, he knocked on her door.

## Think Aloud

Setting change: the power outage makes the house silent

Effect on character: Theo finally hears his sister

Effect on plot: he puts down the controller and knocks

Analysis: the silent setting removes what he was hiding behind, so the plot turns

# Sentence Starters & Signal Words

## GUIDE NOTE

## Answer Frames

Because the setting is \_\_\_\_, the character \_\_\_\_.

The character's choice to \_\_\_\_ causes \_\_\_\_.

This event forces \_\_\_\_ to \_\_\_\_.

The stage direction \_\_\_\_ shows that \_\_\_\_.

## Signal Words

because

so that

as a result

which forces

this causes

leads to

# Task Card: Setting Shapes Character

**FOCUS:** How does the place change the person?

## With your partner

1. Reread the passage and underline three setting details.
2. Next to each, write how it makes the character feel.
3. Choose the detail with the strongest effect.
4. Write one sentence: "Because the setting is \_\_\_\_, the character \_\_\_\_."

## Challenge

Rewrite the scene in a brand-new setting. What must change about the character's behavior — and why?

# Passage A: First Lunch

Maya stopped at the cafeteria door. Three hundred voices bounced off the tile walls, and every table was already full. At her old school she had eaten lunch with the same four friends since third grade. She counted to ten, then carried her tray to the emptiest corner and opened a book she had already finished twice.



## 1. How does the setting most affect Maya in this passage?

- A** It reminds her of the friends she had at her old school.
- B** Its noise and crowding push her to keep to herself.
- C** It convinces her to introduce herself to a new table.
- D** It shows that she has never enjoyed reading.

# Passage A: Evidence Check

Reminder: "...every table was already full. At her old school she had eaten lunch with the same four friends since third grade. She counted to ten, then carried her tray to the emptiest corner..."

## 2. Which detail best shows the setting driving what Maya does next?

- A** "she had eaten lunch with the same four friends since third grade"
- B** "every table was already full"
- C** "a book she had already finished twice"
- D** "She counted to ten"

Be ready to explain your choice out loud using one sentence frame.

# Task Card: Setting Drives the Plot

**FOCUS:** How does the place change what happens next?

## With your partner

1. Find the moment the setting blocks or helps the character.
2. List the two events that follow that moment.
3. Mark the cause-and-effect words you used.
4. Write one sentence linking setting to the next event.

## Challenge

Remove the weather from the passage. Which events collapse? Explain what that proves about interaction.

## Passage B: The Canceled Ferry

The ferry horn never sounded. By noon the harbor was a gray wall of rain, and the sign at the dock read CANCELED. Ravi had promised his grandmother he would be at the hospital by three. He pushed his hands into his pockets, looked at the long road hugging the cliff, and started walking.

### 3. How does the setting drive the plot of this passage?

- A** The storm cancels the ferry, forcing Ravi to walk the cliff road.
- B** The quiet harbor calms Ravi so he decides to wait.
- C** The rain proves that Ravi's grandmother is getting better.
- D** The dock sign shows that Ravi is late for school.

# Passage B: What the Choice Reveals

Reminder: "He pushed his hands into his pockets, looked at the long road hugging the cliff, and started walking."

## 4. What does Ravi's reaction to the setting reveal about him?

- A** He gives up quickly when plans change.
- B** He is determined and keeps the promises he makes.
- C** He dislikes traveling by ferry.
- D** He has never walked the cliff road before.

Find the exact words that support your answer before you share.

# Analyzing a Drama Scene

GUIDE NOTE

## No narrator means...

Nobody explains feelings for you

Dialogue carries the conflict

Stage directions carry the behavior

Silence and pauses are evidence too

## Three questions to ask

What does each character want in this scene?

What does a stage direction show that the words hide?

How does this moment push the plot forward?

# Task Card: Character Moves the Plot

**FOCUS:** How does one choice change everything after it?

## With your partner

1. Find the line where a character makes a choice.
2. Cover everything after it and predict what follows.
3. Uncover and compare with what the text does.
4. Write one sentence: "The choice to \_\_\_\_ causes \_\_\_\_."

## Challenge

Change the character's choice to the opposite. Rewrite the next two events to match.

# Passage C: Drama — The Jersey

NOAH: You told Coach I quit.

ELENA: I told Coach you were sick. (She picks up his jersey and folds it.) You can still walk in tomorrow.

NOAH: And say what?

ELENA: (holding out the jersey) Say you're back. That's all it takes.



## 5. How does Elena's action with the jersey interact with the plot?

- A It ends the conflict of the scene immediately.
- B It pushes Noah toward a decision about returning to the team.
- C It tells the audience where the scene takes place.
- D It proves that Noah really was sick.

## Passage C: Reading Stage Directions

Reminder: "(She picks up his jersey and folds it.)" ... "(holding out the jersey)"

### 6. What do the stage directions add to your understanding of Elena?

- A** She is furious and wants Noah to leave.
- B** She is careless about the team.
- C** She is quietly persistent and is supporting Noah.
- D** She is confused about what happened at practice.

Remember: in drama, actions in parentheses are evidence.

# Check Your Understanding (1 of 2)

**7. In RL.7.3, the word "interact" most nearly means that elements:**

- A** appear in the same story
- B** influence and change one another
- C** are listed in the order they happen
- D** are described by the narrator

**8. A character refuses to leave her flooded town, so her neighbors stay too. This shows:**

- A** setting shaping character
- B** plot shaping setting
- C** a character's choice shaping the plot
- D** no interaction between elements

# Check Your Understanding (2 of 2)

## 9. Which question best analyzes how story elements interact?

- A How does the blizzard change Jonas's plan?
- B What is the weather in the story?
- C Who is the main character?
- D When was the story written?

## 10. In a drama with no narrator, which two elements reveal character best?

- A chapter titles and summaries
- B footnotes and glossaries
- C the theme and the title
- D dialogue and stage directions

# Answer Key

1. **B** Noise and crowding push Maya to keep to herself.

2. **B** Full tables force her move to the corner.

3. **A** Storm cancels the ferry; Ravi must walk.

4. **B** He walks anyway — he keeps his promise.

5. **B** The offered jersey forces a decision.

6. **C** Folding and offering show quiet support.

7. **B** Interact = influence and change each other.

8. **C** Her choice changes what others do.

9. **A** Only A links two elements with change.

10. **D** Drama shows character through speech and action.

# Exit Ticket

## Answer on a sticky note

Pick any story you have read this year.

In two sentences, explain how the setting changed a character's choice — and name the evidence you would use.

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## Remember

Name the element

Name the effect

Quote the evidence

Use a because / so that link